

Technology News

Technologies to watch out for

Five prominent technologies that are going to gain ground this year are cloud computing, tablets and their applications, social networking, memory and USB 3.0.

Cloud computing will let you save, edit, share and access any of your data from anywhere in the world as long as you have an Internet-connected device (computer, tablet, smartphone, etc.). Google is one of the early-starters in this field and has been ramping up infrastructure for a host of cloud-based services. Its upcoming Google Music service, which would be tied-down to Android devices, would run via the cloud. Also, ChromeOS, a full-fledged operating system onto the cloud, would be fully unveiled this year.

The iPad launched last year has set the frenzy for tablets. People would be consuming more of the Web and written content on their touchscreen devices like tablets. These would become the second computer of the home, which might not be used for heavy or graphic-intensive applications but more for browsing around.

Social networking sites will play a much bigger part in our lives. Facebook is already making rapid strides, so much so that it has now started to challenge the supremacy of Google. Google, meanwhile, is working on its own social networking product called 'Google Me'.

Flash memories are increasingly being adopted for mobile-based computing. They are instantly on, from whichever mode you're in, and offer more space for storage. Also, the traditional type of solidstate drives, which offer much faster speed, will become cheaper and see adoption on a mass scale.

USB 3.0 standard for file exchange is up to ten times faster than USB 2.0 and can send and receive data si-



Robot teacher at a primary school in South Korea

multaneously. This year, many more companies will ship their products supporting this standard.

Robot teachers

A group of 30 egg-shaped robots have started teaching English at primary schools in South Korea. Developed by the Korea Institute of Science of Technology, these machines are one metre tall and have a TV panel that displays a female Caucasian face. The robots can wheel around the classroom while speaking to the students and can even read books and dance to music moving their head and arms.

However, the robots are not autonomous, but controlled with a remote by English teachers in the Philippines who can see and hear the children via a remote control system. Cameras detect the teachers' facial expressions and reflect them on their display.

The robots cost £5600 each and will provide extra support for teachers.

Device that reads drivers' mood

An emotional satnav system has been invented that reads the driver's

emotions and adjusts its behaviour accordingly. Cambridge University's scientist-professor Peter Robinson developed the system after running out of patience with his own satnav on complex roads in his hometown.

The device uses sensors to detect facial expressions like frowns, and a voice recognition software to pick up rising irritation in the tone of the driver's voice. A prototype feeds this information into the software attached to a robotic human head that sits alongside the driver. When it detects the driver's anger, it responds with sympathetic expressions.

Researchers say the system could be further developed to avoid overloading a confused driver with information—for example, by turning the volume down on the car radio or avoiding repeating instructions.

Thoughts to control your computer

A new software platform will allow you to control computer commands by just a thought. It has been developed by French scientists and was demonstrated recently at a tech fest at the